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Intersectional Anticipated Discrimination Among Women Experiencing Homelessness in Argentina

Malena Lenta[1] | Jorgelina Di Iorio[2] | José Juan Vázquez[3]

[1]Department of Preventive Psychology, Universidad de Buenos Aires/CONICET, Buenos Aires, Argentina | [2]Department of Social Psychology, Universidad de Buenos Aires/CONICET, Buenos Aires, Argentina | [3]Department of Social Psychology, Universidad de Alcalá, Alcalá de Henares, Spain

Correspondence: José Juan Vázquez (jj.vazquez@uah.es)

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ABSTRACT

Women experiencing homelessness constitute a group with idiosyncratic characteristics and needs that have largely remained invisible. Their discriminatory situation has been studied very little which may limit the design of specific intervention strategies. Buenos Aires (Argentina) is one of the main megalopolises in Latin America, where information on women experiencing homelessness is scarcely available. The main objective of this paper is to analyze different aspects related to intersectional anticipated discrimination perceived by women experiencing homelessness in Buenos Aires ($n = 72$). A structured interview was used to collect the information. The findings show that the vast majority of women experiencing homelessness in Buenos Aires reported experiencing unfair treatment and anticipated discrimination. In addition, more than two-thirds of the women interviewed indicated that they felt they could be insulted or detained without cause, among other unfair treatment. Among the main reasons attributed by the interviewees to these situations of discrimination were the fact of being homeless, being women (cis or trans), and being poor. The results obtained may be useful to guide the design and implementation of policies, services, and programs for women experiencing homelessness with a gender perspective.

1 | Introduction

Homelessness in one of the most extreme forms of poverty and social exclusion (Vázquez, Panadero, and Zúñiga 2017), across global contexts (Busch-Geertsema, Culhane, and Fitzpatrick 2016; Tipple and Speak 2009; Suarez et al. 2018). Among people experiencing homelessness, women comprise an especially vulnerable group (Arangua, Andersen, and Gelberg 2005; Ryan et al. 2009; Vázquez, Panadero, and Pascual 2019) with characteristics, needs, and life trajectories that differ from those of their male counterparts (Guillén, Panadero, and Vázquez 2024; Lenta, Di Iorio, and Vázquez 2023; Matulic-Domandzic et al. 2019; Vázquez and Panadero 2019; Vázquez et al. 2025). In research focused on people living in homelessness, women tend to be underrepresented and gender issues in this group are found to be under-researched (Guillén, Panadero, and Vázquez 2024; Rodriguez-Moreno et al. 2021).

Studies carried out in different cultural contexts indicate that people experiencing homelessness largely present attributes and characteristics considered socially negative (Canham et al. 2022; Hopper 2003; Markowitz and Syverson 2021; Vázquez et al. 2021), some of which (e.g., inadequate hygiene, high substance use, behaviors associated with mental health problems or physical health problems) are highly visible, and to a great extent tend to be attributed controllability. The way in which the stigmatized person is treated, and the subjective experience he or she has, depends to a large extent on the visibility of the stigma (the degree to which it is appreciable) and its controllability (the degree to which the person is considered

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responsible for the stigma). There is a tendency among the housed population to blame people experiencing homelessness for their situation, considering the issue of homelessness an individual problem rather than a systemic structural issue (Vázquez et al. 2021). Not having a home is mainly a poverty issue (Aubry, Klodawsky, and Coulombe 2012), and economic factors are highly significant predictors for access to housing. Scientific literature has highlighted the existence of a strong relationship between discrimination and experiencing traumatic situations (Parent et al. 2024; Sanders-Phillips 2009), as well as experiencing violence (Gómez, Gobin, and Barnes 2021; Lindström 2008). Suffering from discrimination and anticipated discrimination—concern over acts of discrimination even if they may occur infrequently—has a major impact on the lives of those affected (Canham et al. 2022; González-Arribas, Panadero, and Vázquez 2024; Markowitz and Syverson 2021; Reilly, Ho, and Williamson 2022). For some socially excluded groups, discrimination based on defining characteristics of their group (i.e., lack of housing, poverty, gender, ethnic-racial traits, etc.) can have a particularly severe impact on issues such as the affliction of poverty and social marginalization, seeking help, or accessing care services (Corrigan et al. 2003; Markowitz and Syverson 2021; Reilly, Ho, and Williamson 2022; Sanders Thompson, Noel, and Campbell 2004; Thornicroft et al. 2007).

Discrimination is related to public policies, practices, and behaviors that perpetuate inequalities between socially defined groups (Krieger 2014). Perceived stigma (Cechnicki, Angermeyer, and Bielańska 2011), on the other hand, affects people's anticipation of negative consequences that they will experience as a result of having stigmatizing attributes, even when these consequences have not occurred in the past. And, in turn, the anticipation of discrimination has been associated with stress and vigilance situations that have an impact on the deterioration of mental health (Meyer 1995; Wheaton et al. 2013), as well as psychological distress and cardiovascular stress responses (Quinn et al. 2014; Sawyer et al. 2012).

Black feminist theory has long challenged the assumed additivity of oppression (Collins and Bilge 2020; Crenshaw 1995). Crenshaw (1995) coined the term intersectionality to describe Black women's experiences of discrimination, which were rendered unintelligible by legal approaches that considered race and gender separately. Intersectionality has become the central framework for understanding the multiple, interactive, and contextual forms of social disadvantage based on social identity and position (Bowleg 2008; Scheim and Bauer 2019; McCall 2005). Intersectionality analyzes the interconnection of different axes of power relevant to a social and historical reality, which produce situations and relational positions of subordination and privilege of some individuals or social groups with respect to others, based on class, gender, race, sexuality, ability, age, nationality, citizenship status, and so forth (Gelabert 2021). The way in which a person experiences a disadvantage is inevitably determined by the synergistic effect of the different disadvantages he/she suffers (Hancock 2007) so that intersecting vulnerabilities tend to create lifetime deprivations greater than the sum of each of the factors, so that each factor amplifies the effect of the rest giving rise to greater experiences of deprivation (Corus et al. 2016).

A cumulative effect of various types of discrimination can be especially detrimental to people belonging to multiple stigmatizing social identities (Skosireva et al. 2014). In intersectional discrimination, understood as discrimination based on multiple social identities or positions, different grounds of discrimination operate jointly, giving rise to overlapping and interdependent systems of multiple discrimination, so that several grounds of discrimination may operate together. Intersectional discrimination can result in lifetime deprivations greater than the sum of the individual discrimination factors, with each factor amplifying the effect of the others and resulting in greater experiences of discrimination.

Intersectional discrimination and anticipated discrimination have a major impact on people experiencing homelessness (González-Arribas, Panadero, and Vázquez 2024; Vázquez et al. 2021), who may experience discrimination related both to their own homelessness and to other aspects, such as poverty, alcohol or other psychoactive substance use, gender, having "non-White" ethnic-racial traits, or suffering from physical and mental health problems (González-Arribas, Panadero, and Vázquez 2024; Panadero and Vázquez 2024; Skosireva et al. 2014; Vázquez et al. 2021). The role of discrimination in the generation and maintenance of inequalities represents a very relevant area of research since, among other aspects, discrimination, unlike most axes of identity or social position, is modifiable (Bauer 2014; Lofters and O'Campo 2012).

Argentina is a middle-income country in Latin America. Its capital, the Autonomous City of Buenos Aires, has a population of 2,890,151 people, 7.2% of the country's inhabitants. Likewise, 12,806,866 inhabitants live in the Metropolitan Area of Buenos Aires, 32.4% of the country's population. Ten-point five percent of Argentines live on less than 1.90 dollars a day, and 42% are below the national poverty line (Instituto Nacional de Estadísticas y Censos de la República Argentina [INDEC] 2022). The limited information available on people living homeless in Buenos Aires has negative consequences. According to some studies (Palleres and Hidalgo 2018; Farías 2024), Argentina lacks a national policy that provides comprehensive care for people experiencing homelessness. Additionally, there is no unified categorical definition of the problem, and official data on the number and characteristics of people and families living on the streets is not available. The lack of social awareness about the situation of people experiencing homelessness, along with scarce institutional attention, and inadequate public policies, intervention programs, and care structures, are indicators of structural and political violence that violate their right to live in the city and their human rights (Di Iorio 2019; Paiva 2023).

It is also important to demonstrate that in Buenos Aires, various social organizations provide social care to people in street situations. Rosa (2017) identifies three types of organizations: traditional, rights promotion, and social enterprises. The first type is typically religious and focuses on meeting basic needs such as food and hygiene, with volunteers motivated by generosity and charity. The second type aims to promote social rights and not only provide a solution to homelessness, but also ensure legal compliance. The third type of intervention involves collaborating with street dwellers to learn trades or generate enterprises that enable them to leave their current state of

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homelessness. Among the latter type of spaces, we highlight those that consider it crucial to actively involve people who are currently homeless in the initiatives to work on the process of self-autonomy and subjectivation (Heras, Miano, and Pagotto 2017). But most of these spaces work with men, and to a lesser extent with women, families, or children (Paiva 2023).

Regarding the anticipated discrimination by people in street situation, Biaggio (2011) states that it is a daily experience in Buenos Aires. She points out that the relationship of people in this condition with other people is marked by the stigma and the injury that life on the street entails. And that people perceive that they are stigmatized, not because of their individual qualities, but because they belong to a group that is collectively considered different and inferior. The same discriminatory mechanism is discussed in another article on people in street situations in the city of Rosario, Argentina (Bufarini 2020). And both observed strategies of differentiation among street people to avoid feeling part of the collective (homeless) to which they neither feel nor want to belong. However, according to Perelman (2010), not all people in homeless situations perceive discrimination and stigmatization due to their situation. In fact, Perelman (2010) argues that in many cases, these people have a positive view of their own situation, which is not associated with being involved in a stigmatized activity. Likewise, these investigations in the local Argentine context emphasize the relationship between the perception of discrimination and stigma with the street situation, without considering other social positionings such as gender, among others.

In Argentina, there is limited specific scientific literature about women in street situations, and what is available primarily focuses on the impact of violence experienced by women in this situation (Lenta, Di Iorio, and Vázquez 2023; Lenta et al. 2023). However, there are no studies focused on the experiences of discrimination or stigmatization faced by women in street situations, nor on their perception of intersectional discrimination endured. This article aims to analyze how visible presentation, substance use, and victimization are associated with intersectional anticipated discrimination among women experiencing homelessness in Buenos Aires.

2 | Method

Seventy-two women experiencing homelessness were interviewed (67 cisgender, 5 transgender) in Commune 1 (62.5%) and Commune 3 (37.5) of the city of Buenos Aires (Argentina)—the most central communes of the city, in which the largest number of people experiencing homelessness were concentrated. To access the women interviewed, a snowball sampling was used, with the support of key informants: that is, persons experiencing homelessness and people linked to social organizations that provided care to people living homeless. The women participants in the study met the criteria for the following categories of the IGH (Institute of Global Homelessness) "'Global Framework for Understanding Homelessness": "Category 1" refers to people who have nowhere to live, including Subcategories 1A (people sleeping on the streets or in other open spaces) or 1B (people sleeping on public rooftops or buildings and spaces not intended for human habitation). "Category 2" refers to people living in temporary places or crisis accommodation, including Subcategories 2A (people staying in night shelters where they have to renegotiate their accommodation on a daily basis) or 2B (people living in homeless shelters where residents are allocated a specific bed or room).

The recruitment of participants was initiated through contact facilitated by key informants, either on the street or in shelters. Additionally, women on the streets, in squares, and at hospital entrances were also contacted. After locating each of the women experiencing homelessness, the objective of the research was explained to them, and their informed consent to participate was requested. The information was gathered through a structured interview, enabling the resolution of any issues related to the reading and/or comprehension challenges faced by the participants. The structured interview lasted between 45 and 80 min and was hetero-administered. The interviews were conducted on the street or in shelters where women were staying. In both cases, a space away from other people was sought in which the interviewee felt comfortable, to protect the confidentiality of the information and the integrity of the person. Participants were compensated for their time with a kit that included hygiene items such as a face mask and hand sanitizer. The data collection took place between the months of February and April 2021, during the period of the COVID-19 pandemic when preventive social distancing regulations were in effect. This allowed for reduced mobility in different social spaces such as the streets and shelters.

The interviews were not recorded. However, the responses were recorded on a printed questionnaire, which also allowed for observation of the interview process. This decision was made based on the type of instrument used and to establish better rapport with the women participants. Also, they were rewarded with a kit containing a mask and alcohol gel. The study was conducted in compliance with the Internal Review Board [Comité de Ética de Investigación y Experimentación Animal] of the University of Alcalá (Ref. CEIP/2021/2/027). The database was prepared and processed using the SPSS statistical analysis and data management system.

The structured interview covered various topics, beginning with questions about the sociodemographic characteristics of the women participants and their substance use at the time of the interview, including daily consumption of alcohol, marijuana, heroin, cocaine, and/or cocaine paste ("paco"). Then, the questionnaire continued with inquiries about experiences of violence before and after the onset of homelessness situation, health status, relationships, excessive drinking, and/or drug use at any point in their lives, and discrimination. This work focuses on the analysis of the latter topic. The perception of discrimination experienced by the interviewees was collected using the question "Have you ever felt you were treated unfairly?" (with "yes" or "no" response options), and the question "Since you have been living homeless, have you felt discriminated against for this reason?" (You were not allowed to do something, been hassled or made to feel inferior)." The response options were "Never," "Sometimes," "Often," and "Always." Seven items of the Intersectional Anticipated Discrimination Scale (InDI-A) (Scheim and Bauer 2019) appropriate to the idiosyncrasies of women experiencing

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homelessness in Buenos Aires were used to assess the perception of anticipated discrimination. The scores on each of the items were scored from 1 (strongly disagree) to 5 (strongly agree), with final scores ranging from 7 to 35. Scheim and Bauer (2019) conducted a validity and reliability study with 2016 online survey panel data from Canada and the United States ($n = 2583$). They found support for use of the InDI-A as a unidimensional scale. Cronbach's α for the InDI-A was 0.93, and item-total correlations ranged from 0.69 to 0.81.

The database was compiled and analyzed using IBM SPSS 22 for statistical analysis. Descriptive statistics were employed. For comparison purposes, Student's t tests for independent samples were used, and effect sizes were calculated using Cohen's d. We analyzed the differences in mean scores of the seven items of the InDI-A (dependent variables) for women experiencing homelessness in Buenos Aires based on their appearance, experiences of violence, and substance abuse at any time in their lives (independent variables).

3 | Results

3.1 | Sociodemographic Characteristics and Substance Use

As presented in Table 1, the average age of the interviewed women was 43 years, with the initial experience of homelessness occurring at a mean age of 32 years. A majority (90%) of the participants were of Argentine nationality. Additionally, 65.3% had not completed their secondary education, and approximately two-thirds were single. On average, the respondents had been experiencing homelessness for over 3.5 years, with half of them spending their nights outdoors.

Regarding substance use, none of the participants reported daily consumption of alcohol, cocaine, or heroin at the time of the survey. A small proportion, 5.6% (4), indicated daily marijuana use, and one interviewee (1.4%) reported daily use of cocaine paste, also known as "paco."

3.2 | Intersectional Anticipated Discrimination

Among the women experiencing homelessness interviewed in Buenos Aires, 91.4% (64) reported having felt unfairly treated at some time. When respondents were asked the question "Since you have been homeless, have you felt discriminated against for this reason?," the following response percentages were obtained: 11.4% (8) "Never," 2.9% (2) "Sometimes," 32.9% (23) "Many times," and 52.9% (37) "Constantly." Thus, 85.8% (60) of the interviewees indicated that they had often or constantly felt discriminated against for being homeless.

For the seven InDI-A items used, the mean overall score of the respondents was 26.05 (SD = 5.728). The percentages and mean scores for each item are shown in Table 1.

As shown in Table 2, among the women interviewed, 88.9% considered that at that moment or in the near future "they could be singled out, insulted, or disrespected in public" and 82.0% that "they could be assaulted for no reason." 79.2%, 76.4%, and 75.0% indicated that, respectively, they could be treated inappropriately by professionals in social care services, by health personnel, or in stores, bars, or public transport. 56.9% felt that they might be searched, questioned, or detained by police or private security for no reason and 38.9% felt that they would find it difficult to make new friends or have a romantic relationship.

TABLE 1 | Sociodemographic characteristics of women experiencing homelessness in Buenos Aires.

	Women ($n = 72$) Mean (SD)/ percentage (n)
Age	42.9 years (SD = 15.21)
Nationality	
Argentinian	90.3% (65)
Foreign	9.7% (7)
Marital status	
Single	62.5% (45)
Married	6.9% (5)
Legally separated or divorced	11.1% (8)
Separated de facto without legal procedures	9.7% (7)
Widowed	8.3% (6)
Other	1.4% (1)
Level of education	
Incomplete primary education	2.8% (2)
Primary education	11.1% (8)
Incomplete secondary education	51.4% (37)
Secondary education	25.0% (28)
Higher nonuniversity education	5.6% (4)
University studies	4.2% (3)
In the past month she has slept...	
Outdoors	51.4% (37)
In an unsuitable space	65.3% (47
In a shelter	45.8% (33)
Age when she spent at least one week on the street for the first time	32.2 years (SD = 17.08)
Time spent homeless	41.6 months (SD = 57.00)
Had been mother	58.3% (43)
Number of children	3.6 children (SD = 1.83)
Lived with her children	22.2% (16)

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TABLE 2 | Scores on the seven items of the Intersectional Anticipated Discrimination Scale (InDI-A) of women experiencing homelessness in Buenos Aires.

At this time or in the near future, do you believe that…	Item scores ($n = 72$)					Mean[a] (SD)
	Strongly disagree	Disagree	Neither agree nor disagree	Agree	Strongly agree	
You may be singled out, insulted or disrespected in public	8.3% (6)	1.4% (1)	1.4% (1)	43.1% (31)	45.8% (33)	4.17 (1.126)
You could be assaulted for no reason	9.7% (7)	—	8.3% (6)	40.3% (29)	41.7% (30)	4.04 (1.180)
You may be inadequately treated by professionals of social care services (e.g., shelters, soup kitchens, social services, etc.).	12.5% (9)	4.2% (3)	4.2% (3)	27.8% (20)	51.4% (37)	4.01 (1.369)
A doctor, nurse or other health professional may treat you inappropriately	12.5% (9)	1.4% (1)	9.7% (7)	41.7% (30)	34.7% (25)	3.85 (1.274)
You could be inadequately treated in supermarkets, public transport, bars, etc.	15.3% (11)	2.8% (2)	6.9% (5)	47.2% (34)	27.8% (20)	3.69 (1.328)
You could be searched, questioned or detained by police or private security without cause	19.4% (14)	11.1% (8)	12.5% (9)	36.1% (26)	20.8% (15)	3.28 (1.426)
You will find it difficult to make new friends or have a romantic relationship (if you do not have one).	18.1% (13)	19.4% (14)	23.6% (17)	20.8% (15)	18.1% (13)	3.01 (1.369)

[a]1—"Strongly disagree," 2—"Disagree," 3—"Neither agree nor disagree," 4—"Agree," and 5—"Strongly agree."

3.3 | Reasons for Discrimination

The main reasons to which the interviewees attributed the possibility of being discriminated against are shown in Table 2:

As shown in Table 3, the main reasons to which the interviewees attributed the possibility of suffering discrimination were "being homeless," "being poor," and "her sex or gender." Likewise, a relatively high percentage of respondents attributed their "lack of hygiene or dirtiness," their "older or younger age," "being a bad mother," their "character" (bad or difficult character), or their "ethnic-racial traits" to being discriminated against. The majority of the five transgender people interviewed attributed to their "transsexuality or transgenderism" the possibly suffering situations of discrimination. In terms of substance use, about half of the women who reported using psychoactive substances (1 respondent used cocaine paste ("paco") daily and 13 used marijuana regularly) attributed the possibility of discrimination to their drug use. Similarly, about half of the seven foreign-nationality women attributed the possibility of experiencing discrimination to their origin.

More than half of the women interviewed felt that, because they were homeless, they might be singled out, insulted, or disrespected in public, or might be assaulted for no reason; more than a third felt that they might be treated inappropriately by social care professionals, by health professionals, by the police or private security, or in a supermarket, bar or on public transport; and a quarter felt that they would find it difficult to make new friends or have a romantic relationship. More than a quarter of the women interviewed felt that because of their gender they could be singled out, insulted, disrespected in public, or assaulted for no reason, and that because of their lack of hygiene or dirtiness they could be treated inappropriately in supermarkets, public transport, or bars. For their part, more than one-fifth of the women interviewed felt that, because they were poor, they could be treated inappropriately by health care professionals or by a health professional, and could be singled out, insulted, or disrespected in public.

3.4 | Circumstances Affecting the Experience of Intersectional Anticipated Discrimination

As shown in Table 4, women who had some visible trait that could lead to discrimination had higher mean scores on the seven InDI-A items. Likewise, higher scores were reported by respondents who had experienced mistreatment or sexual abuse before the age of 18, as well as those who had experienced physical violence or sexual assault by their partner after the age of 18 and/or had practiced survival sex. The differences in the mean scores are statistically significant, and the effect sizes indicate clear and notable differences. Finally, interviewees who had used drugs to excess at some time in their lives and, especially, those who had drank to excess at some time in their lives, had higher scores. In this regard, very significant differences in the mean scores and a large effect size are observed, indicative of very substantial differences in this respect.

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4 | Discussion

All the women experiencing homelessness interviewed in the city of Buenos Aires had in common that they were poor, women (cis or trans), and experiencing homelessness. Each of these three identities or positions in itself can be a relevant cause of discrimination (Vázquez et al. 2024), and the combination of them, together with other identities or positions pointed out by the interviewees (i.e., high or low age, visible ethnic-racial features, transgender status, substance use, foreign origin, inadequate hygiene, nonnormative mother status) can give rise to serious situations of intersectional discrimination (Vázquez et al. 2021). In intersectional discrimination, the various grounds of discrimination operate together, resulting in lifetime deprivations that are greater than the sum of the individual discrimination factors, with each factor amplifying the effect of the others and causing a greater number of particularly severe discrimination experiences. The wide range of vulnerabilities and different grounds of discrimination affecting women experiencing homelessness helps to explain the high level of discrimination experienced by these women, the vast majority of whom reported having felt unfairly treated and discriminated against because they were living homeless. Perceived and anticipated discrimination can have a very negative impact on issues such as seeking help, accessing care and health services, experiencing social marginalization, accessing housing, or applying for a job (Canham et al. 2022; Corrigan et al. 2003; Reilly, Ho, and Williamson 2022; Sanders Thompson, Noel, and Campbell 2004; Thornicroft et al. 2007).

It is of particular concern that, probably as a result of previous experiences of discrimination, the vast majority of women experiencing homelessness felt that they could be insulted or assaulted without cause, and that they could be treated inappropriately by professionals in social care services, in public establishments, on public transport or by health care personnel. In this sense, various studies have pointed out that persons experiencing homelessness tend to report high levels of unmet health needs (Baggett et al. 2010; Guillén, Panadero, and Vázquez 2021; Hwang et al. 2010) due in part to the numerous barriers to accessing medical care (Kushel. 2001; Reilly, Ho, and Williamson 2022) that contribute to the avoidance of health services (Canham et al. 2022; Bauer 2014; Henderson, Evans-Lacko, and Thornicroft 2013). Anticipated discrimination appears as one of the barriers to access to health services, social care services, or public facilities. In addition, more than half of the women interviewed felt that, because they were homeless, it would be difficult for them to make new friends or have a romantic relationship.

Over half of the interviewed women felt they could be searched, questioned, or detained without cause by police or private security, which is consistent with studies indicating that women experiencing homelessness face a high number of problems with the justice system (Vázquez, Cabrera, and Panadero 2024; Lenta, Di Iorio, and Vázquez 2023). In fact, 20% of the women experiencing homelessness in Buenos Aires had been arrested or detained, mainly when they were already homeless (Lenta, Di Iorio, and Vázquez 2023). The perception of this anticipated discrimination may cause these women not to turn to the police for help or to file complaints when they have been victims of a crime or aggression, which limits access to protection and increases their chances of revictimization. This perception aligns with the fact that a significant portion of physical attacks on homeless individuals originate from security forces (Di Iorio 2019).

The main reasons to which the interviewees attributed discrimination were homelessness, poverty, and gender, which affected all of the interviewees. The interviewees largely considered these to be the main reasons why they might be insulted or assaulted, and why they might be treated inappropriately in social care services, by health personnel, or in stores, bars, or on public transport. From the perspective of intersectional discrimination, it is possible to infer that women consider that the discriminatory and unfair treatment they perceive or expect to perceive is based precisely on their condition of being women (cis or trans) who live in the street space because they are poor. This socially positions them in a space traditionally legitimized for men. And this disruption could appear as a justification for the mistreatment and segregation experienced.

Likewise, a relatively high percentage of interviewees anticipated situations of discrimination derived from presenting other identities or positions, some of them observable (i.e., non-White ethnic-racial traits, age, inadequate hygiene, being transgender) or for less visible aspects (i.e., foreign nationality, being considered a "bad mother," having a "bad character"). The interviewees who presented some of these identities or positions also anticipated in high percentages the suffering of situations of discrimination derived from them, although it should be noted that when several reasons for discrimination operate jointly, some of them may be invisibilized. To a large extent, the women interviewed anticipate the negative consequences they might experience as a result of having a stigmatizing attribute, even if those consequences have not occurred (Cechnicki, Angermeyer, and Bielańska 2011).

Women experiencing homelessness who exhibited visible traits that could lead to discrimination felt particularly vulnerable and were more likely to anticipate experiencing discrimination. One of the main visible features was the racialized aspects (Markowitz and Syverson 2021). Discrimination on ethnic or racial grounds is a historical problem in the Latin American context (Dulitzky 2005), which is reproduced in Argentina against considered "non-White" people, for whom opportunities for upward social mobility are more limited. According to Segato (2006), in Buenos Aires, rather than a programmatic or discursive form of racism, there is a predominance of an emotional racism that is expressed through fear, hostility, or resentment against people living homeless. In the same sense, we agree with Margulis (1999) when he points out that it becomes clear that the phenomenon of racism is not anchored in the idea of race: it refers—and has historically done so—to human groups that, for various reasons, have been disqualified, rendered inferior, mistreated, or excluded. The empirical factors on which this differential treatment is based, or the imaginary reasons invoked, are not always based on the body, on aspects related to the body in which the idea of race has historically been rooted: genes or skin color, traits visible to the eye or presumably hidden behind ancestry or behavior. It is clear that the processes of discrimination, stigmatization, and exclusion,

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TABLE 3 | Reasons why women experiencing homelessness in Buenos Aires believed that they could suffer different situations of discrimination.

At this time or in the near future, do you believe that you will...	Be without a home, % (*n*)	Be poor, % (*n*)	Her sex or gender, % (*n*)	Lack of hygiene or dirtiness, % (*n*)	Be a bad mother, % (*n*)	Her older or younger age, % (*n*)	Her ethnic-racial traits, % (*n*)	Her transsexuality or transgenderism, % (*n*)	Character, % (*n*)	Drug use, % (*n*)	Her ancestry or national origins, % (*n*)
You may be singled out, insulted or disrespected in public	56.9% (41)	20.8% (15)	25.0% (18)	1.4% (1)	5.5% (4)	9.7% (7)	6.9% (5)	5.5% (4)	0.0% (0)	1.4% (1)	6.9% (5)
You could be assaulted for no reason	68.1% (49)	5.5% (4)	33.3% (24)	4.2% (3)	4.2% (3)	11.1% (8)	5.5% (4)	4.2% (3)	1.4% (1)	1.4% (1)	4.2% (3)
May be inappropriately treated by professionals of social care services (e.g., shelters, soup kitchens, social services, etc.).	36.1% (26)	30.6% (22)	11.1% (8)	0.0% (0)	12.5% (9)	2.8% (2)	5.5% (4)	4.2% (3)	11.1% (8)	8.3% (6)	5.5% (4)
A doctor, nurse or other health professional may treat you inappropriately	44.4% (32)	30.6% (22)	13.9% (10)	2.8% (2)	13.9% (10)	11.1% (8)	9.7% (7)	4.2% (3)	0.0% (0)	6.9% (5)	1.4% (1)
You could be inadequately treated in supermarkets, public transport, bars, etc.	40.3% (29)	10.1% (13)	1.4% (1)	26.4% (19)	1.4% (1)	1.4% (1)	11.1% (8)	0.0% (0)	1.4% (1)	0.0% (0)	4.2% (3)
You could be searched, questioned, or detained by police or private security without cause	37.5% (27)	8.3% (6)	4.2% (3)	1.4% (1)	2.8% (2)	2.8% (2)	4.2% (3)	4.2% (3)	1.4% (1)	4.2% (3)	4.2% (3)
You will find it difficult to make new friends or have a romantic relationship (if you do not have one).	23.6% (17)	4.2% (3)	1.4% (1)	1.4% (1)	1.4% (1)	1.4% (1)	0.0% (0)	0.0% (0)	8.3% (6)	0.0% (0)	0.0% (0)

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TABLE 4 | Differences in mean scores of the seven items of the Intersectional Anticipated Discrimination Scale (InDI-A) for women experiencing homelessness in Buenos Aires based on their appearance, experiences of violence, and substance abuse at any time in their lives.

	Scores					
	Yes		No			
Circumstances	***n***	***M* (SD)**	***n***	***M* (SD)**	***t***	**Cohen's *d***
Has a visible trait that could lead to discriminatory behavior	43	24.90 (5.584)	28	27.71 (5.701)	2.053*	0.50
Has suffered						
Abused (before the age of 18)	55	26.98 (5.331)	16	22.69 (6.096)	2.745**	0.78
Sexually abused (before the age of 18) by someone outside of her family	21	28.28 (4.627)	50	25.06 (5.957)	2.213**	0.58
Physical violence (after the age of 18)	57	26.88 (5.898)	14	22.50 (4.702)	2.656**	0.79
Sexual assault (after the age of 18) by a partner	32	27.53 (5.669)	39	24.77 (5.598)	2.057*	049
Survival sex (Had sex in exchange for lodging, food, drugs, etc.)	39	27.41 (4.399)	32	24.31 (6.760)	2.325*	0.55
Has drunk to excess at any time in her life	36	28.42 (3.102)	35	23.54 (6.779)	3.877***	0.92
Has used drugs to excess at any time in her life	28	27.82 (4.846)	43	24.84 (6.047)	2.191*	0.53

*$p \leq 0.05$.; **$p \leq 0.01$.; ***$p \leq 0.001$.

including racism, also refer to groups characterized by other variables: ethnocultural aspects, nationality, and position in productive processes (be poor our in a street situation).

It should be noted that women experiencing homelessness who had experienced physical and/or sexual violence in childhood and adolescence, and those who had experienced intimate partner violence, physical and/or sexual, were more likely to expect to face discrimination. Suffering violence appears as a vulnerability variable for suffering situations of discrimination and for the anticipation of new situations of discrimination. In line with Gelabert (2021), it is possible to affirm that when there is a lack of space for reflection on experiences of violence and discrimination, groups and individuals in a subordinate social position may reproduce representations, knowledge, and/or perceptions that may normalize and/or justify their position vis-à-vis privileged groups, which reinforces intersectional injustices. Respondents who had used drugs to excess at some time in their lives and, especially, those who had drank to excess at some time in their lives, also had a greater perception of being subject to discrimination. This circumstance could be linked to the perception of stigmatization processes of people who use psychoactive substances (Abeldaño et al. 2016), which is exacerbated in the case of women by calling into question sociocultural gender stereotypes (Diez et al. 2020; González-Arribas, Panadero, and Vázquez 2024).

4.1 | Limitations

One of the main limitations of this study is its cross-sectional design, which necessitates caution when attempting to establish causal relationships. Another limitation involves the use of structured interviews for data collection, which may not capture the full depth of intersectional anticipated discrimination among women experiencing homelessness. The exploratory nature of the findings suggests a need for complementary qualitative studies for a deeper understanding. Additionally, the sample size restricted our ability to perform more comprehensive statistical analyses. It is also important to note that data collection occurred during the COVID-19 pandemic, a period marked by significantly reduced social mobility. While the interviewed women did not report experiencing discrimination specifically related to the pandemic, the potential impact of the pandemic context on discriminatory behaviors towards women experiencing homelessness cannot be overlooked. Finally, it should also be noted that the study is limited to a specific sector, Communes 1 and 3 of the city of Buenos Aires. Given that these communes concentrated the largest number of people experiencing homelessness in the city, it is possible to affirm that the results provide elements for understanding the characteristics and needs of homeless women in Buenos Aires, although it is difficult to generalize the results to other contexts.

5 | Conclusion

A high percentage of women experiencing homelessness in Buenos Aires had reported situations of discrimination and anticipated future discrimination in different spheres of their

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daily lives, including those related to the exercise of fundamental rights. This circumstance shows the place of discriminatory practices in the processes of revictimization and institutional and social violence. The reasons attributed to these situations, mainly linked to the very condition of being homeless, to being women (cis or trans), and to being poor, refer to the complexity of a circuit that feeds back into social exclusion and the violation of rights.

Author Contributions

The manuscript has been seen and reviewed by all authors and all authors have contributed to it in a meaningful way.

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Ethics Statement

The research has received institutional review board (IRB) approval by Comité de Ética de la Investigación y de Experimentación Animal (Research Ethics and Animal Experimentation Committee) of the University of Alcalá (Cód. CEI: CEIP/2021/2/027).

Consent

The participants were asked for their informed consent after receiving an explanation of the purpose of the research and the treatment that the data would receive.

Conflicts of Interest

The authors declare no conflicts of interest.

Data Availability Statement

Data available on request from the authors.

Peer Review

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